

Reply to González-Bailón and Lazer: Industry control and conflicts of interest in social media research

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González-Bailón and Lazer (1) offer a charitable reframing of their collaborations with Meta and the influence the company exerted over the research process in their team's 2023 articles. This reframing, however, is inconsistent with their team's own explicit admission that they relied on internal Meta "classifiers, concepts, and categorization methods" to estimate variables like users' political views, topic classifiers to categorize content, including misinformation (2).

Using internal industry classifiers raises serious red flags in two areas. First, the reliance on industry-controlled conceptualization and categorization of data by academic researchers undermines meaningful, intersubjective (3) peer review and the replicability of what Meta claims are highly policy-relevant findings. Second, industry control over data collection and curation raises concerns about the self-interested goals of industry players in such collaborations (4, 5), especially with platforms like Meta being chronically reluctant to disclose to academic researchers how they classify content as disinformation, for instance, even if such sharing is mandated by legislation like the EU's Digital Services Act (6).

Concerns about Meta's long-term strategy to protect their corporate and policy interests are exacerbated by the company's intentional deployment of "break glass" measures to attenuate polarization and change "the active Facebook algorithm in a way that caused the platform to provide less polarizing and more reliable news" during the time the studies in question were in the field (7). None of the publications in *Science* or *Nature* explicitly referenced these break-glass measures. Instead, they were subsequently reported by other researchers in response to the original studies (8). Raising further concerns about the validity of their findings, González-Bailón and Lazer's team openly acknowledges in their response to Bagchi et al. that if "Facebook [had] made different choices regarding how to rank content during the 2020 US elections, our results might have been different" (9).

There are two ways to interpret the fact that these measures were not reported explicitly in the original studies. It is possible that the authors were unaware of Meta's intentional manipulation of key dependent variables in their studies. This would raise serious concerns about Meta withholding information from researchers about what likely amounts to significant distortions in the data underlying this research. In a statement to *Science* magazine, however, Meta's Chad Kiewiet de Jonge insists on a second, more troubling interpretation that his employer "had been forthcoming about the emergency measures to the researchers" (7). While it is beyond the scope of this response to litigate the accuracy of Meta's claims, recent whistleblower allegations that the company also "buried evidence" about the potential harm of their platform to children (10) make the lack of transparency surrounding their break-glass measures doubly troubling.

In a 2022 editorial, *Science*'s Holden Thorp references two standards to assess whether research should be retracted: "whether the data in a paper is reliable or not ... [and] who has been responsible for generating that data" (11). Unfortunately, the fact base surrounding the Meta studies suggests answers to both questions that spell trouble for social media research.

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